Playtest session script (researcher)

About 25–30 minutes per participant. Lines in quotes are what you say out loud. Everything else is for you only.

Before they arrive

- Check which condition this participant number gets (diegetic or non-diegetic) in your records.
- Open `RESEARCHGAME.app`, choose that condition on the launcher and **stop there**. Don't press Start until they're sitting down.
- Have these ready: the info sheet and consent form, the questionnaire (paper, or the Google Form on the participant link), and a recorder for the interview.
- Write down the participant number. It goes on the questionnaire. Their name never does.

1. Welcome and consent (~3 min)

> "Hi, thanks for coming. Today you'll play a short 2D platformer for about 15 minutes. After that there's a quick questionnaire and a short chat about how it went.
>
> We're testing the game, not you. There are no right or wrong answers, and it's completely fine if you die a lot.
>
> Please read this information sheet, and sign the consent form if you're happy to take part. You can stop at any time without giving a reason."

- Let them read it. Answer any questions. Collect the signed form.
- If you're balancing the groups: "Roughly how often do you play video games: never, sometimes, or often?"

2. Briefing (~1 min)

> "Use the left and right arrow keys to move and the spacebar to jump. Get to the end of each level. If you fail, the game will respond in some way. Just keep playing as you normally would.
>
> I won't be able to help while you play, so do your best on your own. Let me know when you're done, or I'll stop you at around 15 minutes."

- Press **Start**, hand them the keyboard, and step back.
- **Don't** say "diegetic", "non-diegetic", "companion feedback" or "frustration". Don't tell them there are two versions.

3. Gameplay (up to ~15 min)

- Stay quiet and neutral. If they ask for help: "Just do what you think is best."
- Optional notes: rough number of deaths, where they got stuck, any visible reactions or comments.
- Stop at ~15 minutes, or earlier when they finish Level 5 (it returns to the launcher). Close the game before you turn the screen back to them so they don't see the condition picker.

> "Great, that's the end of the game part. Thanks!"

4. Questionnaire (~3 min)

> "Please answer these based on the game you just played. There are no right answers. Go with your first instinct."

- Give them the paper form (page 1 only) or the Google Form. Check the participant number is filled in.

- Note the participant number and condition in your own records. The form doesn't record the condition.

5. Interview (~5 min)

> "Last part: a few questions about how it went. Is it okay if I record the audio? It'll be transcribed and anonymised."

Start recording only after they say yes. Ask these questions and follow up with "Can you tell me more about that?"

1. "How did you feel when you failed in the game?"
2. "What did the game do when you failed? Did it help you work out what to do differently?"
3. "How capable or skilled did you feel as you played? Did that change over time?"
4. "Was there anything that annoyed or frustrated you?"
5. "If you could keep playing, would you want to? Why or why not?"

6. Debrief and thanks (~2 min)

> "That's everything, thank you! The study compares two ways a game can show you what went wrong when you fail. Some people get feedback from the companion character and some get on-screen text and arrows. You played one of them. Please don't tell other people who might take part, because it could affect their results. Any questions?"

- Stop the recording and save it under the participant number.
- Reset the game to the launcher for the next participant.